

International Institute of Information Technology, Hyderabad

Introduction to Human Sciences (HS8.102)
Spring 2026

Quiz Two
((Political Science Module))
Date- March 30, 2026

SECTION B

Max Time: 45 minutes

Max Marks: 40

Question 1 (600 words)

Marks: 30

Discuss the concept of politics as power. Explain the three faces of power and their significance in understanding political processes.

Introduction (politics as power): 2 **marks**

Harold Lasswell's definition and interpretation (Who gets what, when and how): 3 **marks**

First face of power (decision-making): 6 **marks**

Second face of power (agenda-setting): 6 **marks**

Third face of power (thought control): 6 **marks**

Marxist interpretation: 3 **marks**

Feminist interpretation: 3 **marks**

Conclusion: 1 **mark**

Question 2 (200 words)

Marks: 10

Write short notes on **any one** of the following

(1) Categories of Human Rights (5 x 2 marks)

(2) Role of the State (5 x 2 Marks)

Politics as power

The fourth definition of politics is both the broadest and the most radical. Rather than confining politics to a particular sphere (the government, the state or the 'public' realm), this view sees politics at work in all social activities and in every corner of human existence. As Adrian Leftwich proclaimed in *What is Politics? The Activity and Its Study* (2004), 'politics is at the heart of *all* collective social activity, formal and informal, public and private, in *all* human groups, institutions and societies'. In this sense, politics takes place at every level of social interaction; it can be found within families and amongst small groups of friends just as much as amongst nations and on the global stage. However, what is it that is distinctive about political activity? What marks off politics from any other form of social behaviour?

Focus on . . .

'Faces' of power

Power can be said to be exercised whenever A gets B to do something that B would not otherwise have done. However, A can influence B in various ways. This allows us to distinguish between different dimensions or 'faces' of power:

- **Power as decision-making:** This face of power consists of conscious actions that in some way influence the content of decisions. The classic account of this form of power is found in Robert Dahl's *Who Governs? Democracy and Power in an American City* (1961), which made judgements about who had power by analysing decisions in the light of the known preferences of the actors involved. Such decisions can nevertheless be influenced in a variety of ways. In *Three Faces of Power* (1989), Keith Boulding distinguished between the use of force or intimidation (the stick), productive exchanges involving mutual gain (the deal), and the creation of obligations, loyalty and commitment (the kiss).
- **Power as agenda setting:** The second face of power, as suggested by Bachrach and Baratz (1962), is the ability to prevent decisions being made: that is, in effect, 'non-decision-making'. This involves the ability to set or control the political agenda, thereby preventing issues or proposals from being aired in the first place. For instance, private businesses may exert power both by campaigning to defeat proposed consumer-protection legislation (first face), and by lobbying parties and politicians to prevent the question of consumer rights being publicly discussed (second face).
- **Power as thought control:** The third face of power is the ability to influence another by shaping what he or she thinks, wants, or needs. This is power expressed as ideological indoctrination or psychological control. This is what Lukes (2004) called the 'radical' view of power, and it overlaps with the notion of 'soft' power (see p. 428). An example of this would be the ability of advertising to shape consumer tastes, often by cultivating associations with a 'brand'. In political life, the exercise of this form of power is seen in the use of propaganda and, more generally, in the impact of ideology (see p. 28).

At its broadest, politics concerns the production, distribution and use of resources in the course of social existence. Politics is, in essence, power: the ability to achieve a desired outcome, through whatever means. This notion was neatly summed up in the title of Harold Lasswell's book *Politics: Who Gets What, When, How?* (1936). From this perspective, politics is about diversity and conflict, but the essential ingredient is the existence of scarcity: the simple fact that, while human needs and desires are infinite, the resources available to satisfy them are always limited. Politics can therefore be seen as a struggle over scarce resources, and power can be seen as the means through which this struggle is conducted.

Advocates of the view of politics as power include feminists and Marxists. The rise of the women's liberation movement in the 1960s and 1970s, bringing with it a growing interest in feminism, stimulated more radical thinking about the nature of 'the political'. Not only have modern feminists sought to expand the arenas in which politics can be seen to take place, a notion most boldly asserted through the radical feminist slogan 'the personal is the political', but they have also tended to view politics as a process, specifically one related to the exercise of power over others. This view was summed by Kate Millett in *Sexual Politics* (1969), in which she defined politics as 'power-structured relationships, arrangements whereby one group of persons is controlled by another'.

Marxists, for their part, have used the term 'politics' in two senses. On one level, Marx (see p. 41) used 'politics' in a conventional sense to refer to the apparatus of the state. In the *Communist Manifesto* ([1848] 1967), he (and Engels) thus referred to political power as 'merely the organized power of one class for oppressing another'. For Marx, politics, together with law and culture, are part of a 'superstructure' that is distinct from the economic 'base' that is the real foundation of social life. However, he did not see the economic 'base' and the legal and political 'superstructure' as entirely separate. He believed that the 'superstructure' arose out of, and reflected, the economic 'base'. At a deeper level, political power, in this view, is therefore rooted in the class system; as Lenin (see p. 99) put it, 'politics is the most concentrated form of economics'. As opposed to believing that politics can be confined to the state and a narrow public sphere, Marxists can be said to believe that 'the economic is political'. From this perspective, civil society, characterized as Marxists believe it to be by class struggle, is the very heart of politics.

Rights

Human Rights

- (i) **security rights** that protect people against crimes such as murder, massacre, torture and rape;
- (ii) **liberty rights** that protect freedom in areas such as belief, expression, association, assembly and movement;
- (iii) **political rights** that protect the liberty to participate in politics through actions such as communicating, assembling, protesting, voting and serving in public office;
- (iv) **due process rights** that protect against abuses of the legal system such as imprisonment without trial, secret trials and excessive punishments;
- (v) **equality rights** that guarantee equal citizenship, equality before the law and non-discrimination; and
- (vi) **welfare rights** (or 'economic and social rights') that require the provision of education to all children and protections against severe poverty and starvation.

State

Role of the State

- **Minimal State**- The state is merely a protective body, its core function being to provide a framework of peace and social order within which citizens can conduct their lives as they think best.
- A **developmental state** is one that intervenes in economic life with the specific purpose of promoting industrial growth and economic development.
- Whereas developmental states practise interventionism in order to stimulate economic progress, **social-democratic states** intervene with a view to bringing about broader social restructuring, usually in accordance with principles such as fairness, equality and social justice.
- While developmental and social-democratic states intervene in economic life with a view to guiding or supporting a largely private economy, **collectivized states** bring the entirety of economic life under state control.
- The essence of **totalitarian state** is the construction of an all-embracing state, the influence of which penetrates every aspect of human existence. The state brings not only the economy, but also education, culture, religion, family life and so on under direct state control.